



United States
Attorney's Office
Northern District of Illinois



U.S. Postal Service Employee Indicted for Alleged Workers' Compensation Fraud

Friday, December 19, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Northern District of Illinois

CHICAGO — A United States Postal Service employee has been indicted on federal fraud charges for allegedly collecting augmented workers' compensation benefits to which she was not entitled.

In 2012, GRACIELA VENEGAS began receiving workers' compensation benefits for an injury she sustained in the performance of her Postal Service duties. Venegas claimed her spouse as a dependent, which entitled her to receive augmented benefits. The couple divorced in 2013, and the ex-spouse then passed away in 2014.

An indictment returned on Monday in U.S. District Court in Chicago alleges that Venegas fraudulently continued to claim the spouse as a dependent after the divorce and death. From 2013 to 2024, while employed by the Postal Service, Venegas fraudulently received monthly augmented workers' compensation payments amounting to an additional 8 and 1/3 percent of her pre-injury monthly pay, the indictment states. In total, Venegas fraudulently pocketed \$51,776 in augmented benefits to which she knew she was not entitled, the indictment states.

Venegas, also known as "Graciela Salgado," 66, of Chicago, is charged with five counts of wire fraud and one count of knowingly making a false statement to the U.S. Department of Labor. Each wire fraud count carries a maximum sentence of 20 years in federal prison, while the false statement charge is punishable by up to five years. Arraignment is set for Jan. 6, 2026, at 11:00 a.m., before U.S. Magistrate Judge Laura K. McNally.

The indictment was announced by Andrew S. Boutros, United States Attorney for the Northern District of Illinois, and Dennis Bishop, Special Agent in Charge of the Central Area Field Office of the U.S. Postal Service–Office of Inspector General. The government is represented by Special Assistant U.S. Attorney Diya Rattan.

"Workers' compensation benefits provide a lifeline to workers who are injured on the job and unable to perform their duties," said U.S. Attorney Boutros. "Committing fraud upon this important

program undermines the financial stability of the insurance system, increases costs for businesses and consumers, and harms truly injured workers. Our Office will continue to work with our law enforcement partners to hold accountable those who seek to collect workers' compensation benefits to which they are not entitled."

"The U.S. Postal Service paid \$1.5 billion in workers' compensation costs in fiscal year 2024, and the majority of postal employees who collect compensation benefits have legitimate claims due to on-the-job injuries," said SAC Bishop. "However, a certain percentage abuse the system and cost the Postal Service millions of dollars in fraudulent claims and enforcement costs. Today's charges send a clear message that the USPS OIG and the United States Attorney's Office, Northern District of Illinois, remain committed to safeguarding the integrity of this benefit program and ensuring the accountability and integrity of U.S. Postal Service employees."

The public is reminded that an indictment is not evidence of guilt. The defendant is presumed innocent and entitled to a fair trial at which the government has the burden of proving guilt beyond a reasonable doubt.

[venegas_indictment.pdf](#)

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